

San Franciscans always showed an appreciation for music and art—even in the days when the city was a gold-rush-era Helidorado. There are very few metropolises in the United States today with higher general levels of taste and culture than San Francisco—and the city's cultural traditions go back well over a century.

Denver had its Occidental Hall and the Tabor Grand Opera House—the latter built by H. A. W. Tabor, as crude a character as can be found in American history. The Tabor Grand Opera House was a showplace of the West. Operas, concerts and lectures were given there—and Denverites packed the auditorium, listened attentively and, if contemporary accounts are to be believed, appreciatively.

I believe I am qualified to comment personally on the culture-shunning myth of the American frontier. My own forebears came to the United States in the Eighteenth Century. They were pioneers, mainly farmers, who came to America to build their futures in the wilderness. It was for one of them, James Getty, that Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, was named. Judging by the memorabilia these people left behind, they and large numbers of their contemporaries hungered for culture and knowledge in all forms. They read avidly, passing books—particularly the classics—from hand to hand. They dreamed of the day when they could have good oil paintings on the walls of the good homes they

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hoped to build. They tried to teach their children to appreciate and love fine literature, art and music.

My own father was born in 1855 on an Ohio farm—and a very poor and unproductive farm at that. His widowed mother was impoverished and life was anything but simple and easy. Yet, the thirst for intellectual and cultural betterment was great. My father worked his way through school and college, and one of his greatest sources of pride was his membership in the university's literary society.

I, myself, had a heaping helping of life on America's last frontier when, in 1904, my father, mother and I went to the Oklahoma Territory. Clapboard